

Title

Functional Burden and Systemic Mental Health Effects in Preadolescents Receiving Guided Online Behavioral Therapy for Anxiety: Secondary Analysis from a Two-Year Trial

Abstract

While primary anxiety symptom reduction is important, understanding broader functional and psychological outcomes is essential for clinical decision-making. In our 465-participant trial of internet-delivered therapy versus psychoeducation, we examined secondary endpoints including anxiety-related functional impairment, depressive symptoms, and perceived distress. At 12 months, the intervention group showed greater reductions in anxiety-related activity disruption (mean difference 3.2 points on functional impact scale; 95% CI 1.5-4.9; $p < 0.001$) and depressive symptomatology (mean difference 1.1 points; 95% CI 0.8-1.4; $p < 0.001$). These differences remained significant at 24 months. Effect sizes for anxiety-related impairment were larger (Cohen's $d = 0.48$ at 12 months) than for mood symptoms ($d = 0.31$). Approximately 68% of the intervention group achieved clinically significant improvement on at least one secondary measure compared with 41% in the control group. Among multiple anxiety dimensions assessed, social anxiety showed the largest treatment response.